They are distributed throughout the world. They are herbivorous animals feeding on grass and vegetables like turnips, carrots and lettuce. Rabbits are **gregarious** (moving in groups) animals

DO YOU KNOW?

The pygmy rabbit was listed as a threatened species in Washington in 1990, because of decline in its population size and distribution due to habitat loss. In March 2003, the Columbia Basin Pygmy Rabbit was federally listed as an endangered species.

13.2.2 External Morphology

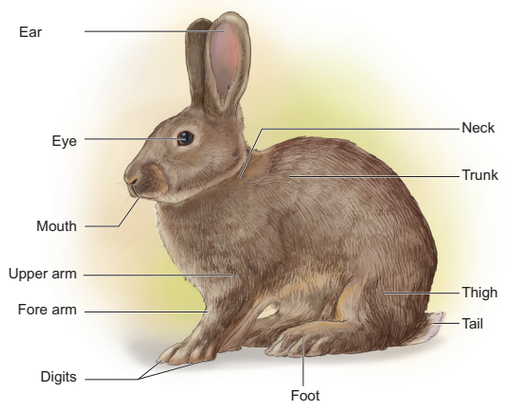


Figure 13.5 Rabbit- External features

Shape, Size and Colouration: It has an elongated and cylindrical body. Males and females are of the same size. They grow about 45 cm in length and weigh about 2.25 kg as adult. The colour varies from white to black and white. Body is covered with fur which serves to keep it warm.

Body-division: The body of the rabbit is divisible into the head, neck, trunk and tail.

Head: Head is ovoid, flattened and bears a truncate snout. It contains mouth, external nares, eyes, ears and vibrissae. The **mouth** is a transverse slit-like bounded by upper lip and lower lip. Just above the mouth are two oblique openings called **nostrils**. From each side of the upper lip tactile hairs or **vibrissae** (whiskers) project outwards. A pair of large, movable **external ear** or **pinnae** is situated at the top of the head.

Neck: The neck connects the head with the trunk. It helps to turn the head.

Trunk: The trunk is divisible into an anterior **thorax** and a posterior **abdomen**. In females, four or five **teats** or **nipples** are present on the ventral surface between the thorax and abdomen.

The trunk bears two pairs of **pentadactyl limbs**. The forelimbs are shorter than the hind limbs. All the digits bear claws.

The anus is present at the posterior end of the abdomen at the base of tail. In females on the ventral side a slit like **vulva** is present. In males **penis** is present in the ventral side of anus. The male has a pair of testes enclosed by **scrotal sacs**.

Tail: The tail is short. It is used to give signals to other rabbits in the event of danger.

Integument (Skin): The integument forms the outer covering of the body. The structures which are derived from it are **hairs, claws, nails** and glands like **sweat glands, sebaceous glands** and **mammary glands**.

Mammary glands are modified glands of the skin. They secrete milk and help in nourishing young ones. The sweat glands and sebaceous glands embedded in the skin regulate the body temperature.

13.2.3 Coelom (Body cavity)

Rabbit is a coelomate animal. The body is divisible into **thoracic cavity** and **abdominal cavity** separated by transverse partition called **diaphragm**. Diaphragm is the characteristic feature of mammals. Breathing movements are brought by the movement of the diaphragm.

Lungs and heart lie in the thoracic cavity, whereas, abdominal cavity encloses digestive and urinogenital system.

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